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# Exploring talent management in practice: an Arab country-specific empirical investigation



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## Abstract

**Purpose** – Despite the proliferation of studies on talent management (TM), few studies focus on the perspectives of human resource management (HRM) representatives. Furthermore, there is a dearth of studies that explore talent philosophies and TM in practice in private organizations in emerging economies, such as those of the Arab Middle East (AME) region. Consequently, the purpose of this study is to explore talent philosophies and TM in practice in the country-specific context of Lebanon.

**Design/methodology/approach** – This study was exploratory in nature and followed a qualitative interpretive methodology. It capitalized on in-depth, semi-structured interviews with HRM representatives.

**Findings** – The findings of this study indicated relative consensus in talent philosophies across organizations in four industries; talent was largely perceived as exclusive, despite disagreements on whether it was stable or developable. Differences were identified in terms of how TM was understood in organizations and also how it was executed in practice in terms of talent identification and recruitment, training and development, performance assessment and talent retention.

**Originality/value** – This study is the first to empirically explore talent philosophies and TM in practice in the context of Lebanon. It is also among the few studies to extend the use of institutional theory (IT) to talent philosophies and TM practices. The originality of this study is also derived from its focus on the practices of HRM departments through using feedback from HRM representatives.

**Keywords** Talent philosophies, Talent management, Human resource management, Institutional theory, Lebanon, Arab Middle East

**Paper type** Research paper

## Introduction

In today's highly volatile and dynamic market environment, talent management (TM) has emerged as a source of competitive advantage (Collings *et al.*, 2018; Khoreva *et al.*, 2017; Meyers and van Woerkom, 2014; Tarique and Schuler, 2010; Tlaiss *et al.*, 2017). However, research on TM remains fragmented and underdeveloped, with no stable theoretical foundation (Collings *et al.*, 2018; Collings and Mellahi, 2009; Mellahi and Collings, 2010; Scullion and Collings, 2011) and no consensus on the nature of talent or talent philosophies (Meyers *et al.*, 2019; Lewis and Heckman, 2006) or the meaning or scope of TM in practice (Thunnissen, 2016; Gallardo-Gallardo and Thunnissen, 2016). These shortcomings are further endorsed by the currently available empirical evidence that also suffers from theoretical and methodological inconsistencies (Tlaiss *et al.*, 2017; Khoreva *et al.*, 2017). A closer look at the empirical evidence highlights further gaps. For example, to date, most TM empirical research studies have been conducted in large, multinational corporations (MNCs) in Western contexts (e.g. Festing *et al.*, 2013; Tlaiss *et al.*, 2017), making the applicability of this research to organizations in non-Western contexts highly contended (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014). If and when TM-related studies are available based on the Middle East context, they are primarily cross cultural (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014) or theoretical (Gallardo-Gallardo and Thunnissen, 2016) in nature. This posits a critical knowledge gap, especially as most scholarly work has tended to ignore the role of contextual factors on TM, despite recent evidence arguing that TM challenges and issues may vary significantly in organizational and national contexts (Collings *et al.*, 2018; Festing *et al.*, 2013). To date, few studies have explored

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the different meanings attributed to talent across cultures and their impact on TM (Gallardo and Thunnissen, 2016; Meyers *et al.*, 2019). Hence, the increase in scholarly calls for more empirical studies that take into consideration the notion that talent is conceptualized and TM is practiced differently in varying national contexts (Thunnissen, 2016; Tlaiss *et al.*, 2017).

In response to these calls, this paper empirically explores talent philosophies, approaches to TM, as well as TM in practice in organizations in the country-specific context of Lebanon. More specifically, this paper explores how TM is executed in practice through exploring the salient talent philosophies and approaches to TM in Lebanese organizations as reported by human resource (HR) practitioners. Thus, this paper asks (1) how is talent defined and TM practiced in Lebanese organizations? And (2) what are the factors that impact the practice of TM in Lebanese organizations? To achieve the objectives of this study and to improve and enlarge our understanding of TM as a practical phenomenon, empirical data from 21 human resource management (HRM) representatives working in several organizations in Lebanon are drawn upon. Close attention is paid to Lebanon's national factors such as economic conditions, political instability and supply and demand of labor and their impact on TM practices and is investigated through institutional theory (IT) (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983) to assess the impact of institutional forces on organizational practices of TM.

This paper is structured in the following manner: in section 2, TM literature is reviewed and reflected upon in the national context of Lebanon using IT. In sections 3 and 4, the methodology used is outlined and the findings are presented, respectively. In section 5, a discussion of the findings is given, and in section 6, attention is drawn toward the theoretical and practical implications of the study. In section 7, the paper concludes and recommendations are made for future studies.

## Review of literature

Despite substantial evidence supporting the strategic role of TM in organizational success and competitive advantage (Gallardo-Gallardo and Thunnissen, 2016; Meyers *et al.*, 2019; Valverde *et al.*, 2013), the nature of talent and the concept of TM remain unclear, with a disturbing lack of theoretical development in this area (Collings and Mellahi, 2009; Thunnissen, 2016).

### *Talent philosophies*

Meyers and van Woerkom (2014) argued that the lack of agreement on the definitions and theoretical frameworks for TM can be traced back to the "dissimilar interpretations of the term talent: what is talent or who do we consider talented?" (p. 193). For example, talent has been operationalized as human capital (Nijs *et al.*, 2014), which can be assessed in terms of value and uniqueness (Lepak and Snell, 1999). While value refers to the potential to contribute to and advance an organization's competitive position, uniqueness refers to the extent to which human capital is difficult to replace. These interpretations are critical as they are based on talent philosophies defined as "fundamental assumptions and beliefs about the nature, value, and instrumentality of talent that are held by a firm's key decision makers" (Meyers and van Woerkom, 2014, p. 193). In other words, talent philosophies capture how management defines talent, what is considered talent, how valuable they consider talented employees to be and their approach to the deployment of talented people to maximize performance (Meyers *et al.*, 2019). Talent philosophies have been proposed along the exclusive/inclusive and stable/developable dimensions (Lewis and Heckman, 2006; Stahl *et al.*, 2007; Meyers and van Woerkom, 2014). While the first dimension focuses on the assumed rareness of talent (exclusive) versus assuming that everyone has talent (inclusive) (Stahl *et al.*, 2007), the second dimension focuses on whether talent is stable (innate) or can be developed (acquired). Based on these two dimensions, Meyers and van Woerkom (2014) developed a conceptual framework of four different talent philosophies that varied along these "areas of disagreement" (Meyers *et al.*, 2019).

The *exclusive/stable* talent philosophy reflects a managerial belief that less than 20% of employees are talented or gifted with special skills and capabilities (Tansley, 2011). Consequently, HR managers divide the workforce into two groups: the majority of the employees and a small group of star performers or talented employees who are likely to make substantial contributions to organizational performance. This smaller group receives preferential treatment to bind them to the organization through incentives such as bonuses and rapid advancement (Micheals *et al.,* 2001 in Lewis and Heckman, 2006). Proponents of the *exclusive/developable* talent philosophy believe that talent is rare but can be wasted if it remains undiscoverable. Consequently, talented employees are considered to constitute around 10 to 20% of the employee population and show the potential to perform more challenging tasks and are thus granted training and development opportunities to unlock their potential (Gagne, 2004; Meyers *et al.*, 2019). HR managers who hold an *inclusive/stable* talent philosophy believe that every individual possesses stable, positive traits. They appreciate the strengths of all employees, regardless of how diverse these strengths are as they strive to maximize person–job fit to further help employees use their strengths and thus perform at their best (Meyers *et al.*, 2019). Managers holding the *inclusive/developable* talent philosophy believe that all employees can become star performers through dedicated training. In other words, this philosophy reflects a genuine belief in the human capacity to grow and develop in organizational settings with a strong focus on the training and development of employees (Meyers *et al.*, 2019).

Recent TM studies argue that the difference in underlying talent philosophies is not only conceptual but also organizational and culturally based (Festing *et al.*, 2013). Hence, TM scholars have called for more studies exploring talent philosophies in non-Western contexts, especially in Arab Middle East (AME) contexts (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014).

### *Key streams of thought on talent management*

Given the confusion on its definitions, terms and assumptions (Lewis and Heckman, 2006), TM does not have a "single consistent or concise definition" (Aston and Morton, 2005, p. 30). Nevertheless, there are four distinct streams of thought regarding TM (Lewis and Heckman, 2006; Boudreau and Ramstad, 2005, 2007; Collings and Mellahi, 2009; Mellahi and Collings, 2010). The first stream perceives TM as the rebranding of HRM activities as it comprises a collection of typical HR practices, such as recruitment, selection, development, leadership and succession planning (Lewis and Heckman, 2006). The second stream's focus is more internal than external and is geared toward the development of talent pools. It is often close to what is commonly known as succession planning or human resource planning and builds on workforce planning, doing little to advance the theory or practical aspects of HR (Lewis and Heckman, 2006). The third stream focuses on the generic management of talent, with no regard to specific positions or organizational boundaries (Collings and Mellahi, 2009) and promotes the idea that organizations should only hire "A performers" and terminate the contracts of "C performers" through the process of "top grading" (Micheals *et al.,* 2001 in Lewis and Heckman, 2006).

The fourth TM stream argues that the focus should be on identifying strategic jobs (Becker and Huselid, 2006) or roles that have above average impact (Boudreau and Ramstad, 2007) and on developing a talent pool of high performing individuals, through external recruitment and internal development. The objective is to develop employees with broad competencies that would fit a range of roles, in comparison to succession planning which focuses on developing a narrow, specialized skill set with a particular succession role in mind

(Cappelli, 2008). The final element of TM in this stream recognizes the importance of a differentiated HR architecture to ensure the continued commitment of these incumbents (Collings and Mellahi, 2009; Mellahi and Collings, 2010). Scholars supporting this approach believe that the differentiated contribution of these high performers to the organization's competitive advantage legitimizes disproportionate investment (Becker and Huselid, 2006; Lepak and Snell, 1999).

Notwithstanding the contribution of these different streams, Valverde *et al.* (2013) questioned both their claims of universality, given that they have been conceptualized and empirically tested in Western contexts (Valverde *et al.*, 2013) and also their transferability to non-Western contexts, given the minimal attention attributed to organizational and cultural contexts. Hence, the increase in scholarly calls for more empirical studies in nontraditional countries' contexts (Gallardo-Gallardo and Thunnissen, 2016; Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014; Thunnissen, 2016).

*The research context: Lebanon*

As TM expands as a theory and practice across countries (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014), Schuler *et al.* (2011) emphasized the need to understand the role of contextual factors in shaping TM. To that end, this current study leverages IT (Scott, 2014) as its main theoretical framework, given its widely accepted usage in TM-related studies, including those in Arab world career-related studies of women in the AME (Sidani and AlAriss, 2014). According to IT, institutions are social structures with three pillars that provide meaning to social life, stability and support, namely, cultural-cognitive, regulatory and normative (Scott, 2014). Organizations that share the same context are pressurized to adopt similar practices as a result of three types of pressure – mimetic, coercive and normative – per the concept of isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983).

The cultural-cognitive pillar refers to the interpretations of the national culture and traditions within a certain country. Taking the cultural-cognitive pillar into consideration, the Lebanese society is described as collectivist in nature (Tlaiss, 2014) with family as the backbone of society with group and family needs and obligations taking precedence over personal objectives (Barakat, 1993). The Lebanese Civil War (1975–1990), resulted in a dire economic situation characterized by high unemployment levels, very low salaries and poor living conditions (The World Fact Book, 2020). This difficult socioeconomic situation led to the heavy migration of highly educated Lebanese to the neighboring Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) in pursuit of better living conditions and more attractive job prospects (Tlaiss, 2014). Over the past several decades, despite the end of the Civil War, the economic situation in Lebanon has not improved due to an unstable political backdrop, lack of security, corruption and the nearby Syrian conflict. Notwithstanding testing economic and political conditions, Lebanon's educational system continues to improve and has witnessed an increase in the number of private American and French universities operating there (The Muhanna Foundation, 2010). The growth in universities has paved the way for an increase in the number of university graduates and resulted in a supply of educated human capital that exceeds local demand. Seeking stability and better living standards, young, educated Lebanese nationals continue to emigrate (Tlaiss, 2014). For those that stay, a surplus of educated workers acts as a drag on career prospects. These cognitive-cultural forces and the macro socioeconomic factors are experienced by Lebanese organizations and exert mimetic pressure per the concept of isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983). Hence, organizations in Lebanon adopt similar practices. For example, in a study that examined the career paths of Lebanese managers, Tlaiss (2014) revealed that careerists were more likely to follow a traditional career path (characterized by vertical career progression with commitment and loyalty to one or two employers) due to the difficult economic situation that motivates managers to focus on job security and maintaining a steady income. *Wasta* is another factor that also significantly impacts careerists in Lebanon and the Arab region (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014; Tlaiss and Kauser, 2011), whereby individuals with personal connections to powerful people and politicians have access to better jobs and progression opportunities. In a study that solicited the feedback of Arab employees across four different countries, Tlaiss and Kauser (2011) highlighted the prevalence of corruption in Arab countries and the frequent use of *wasta* by Arabs to gain preferential employment and promotions.

The regulatory pillar of IT is concerned with rules and laws that act as control mechanisms (Scott, 2014) and hence, coercive pressure refers to the role of government in imposing regulative power on organizations (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983). Successive governments in Lebanon have launched a number of initiatives aimed at improving the country's economic and financial conditions and reducing corruption but have not been successful. Hence, it was not surprising to see Lebanon default on its debt in March 2020 (The Guardian, 2020). The normative pillar of IT refers to the impact that standards of preferred structure and behavior have on decision-making within organizations. No study to date has reported on efforts exerted by any professional entities to enforce policies against the usage of *wasta* in organizations. Despite the presence of international professional bodies and associations that set the standards for the profession of HRM, such as the Chartered Institute of Personnel and Development (CIPD) or the Society for Human Resource Management (SHRM), there have been no guidelines issued to members to help promote transparency in the implementation of hiring and promotions or in performance assessments.

## The research methodology

Given the limited knowledge about TM in Lebanon and the need to uncover and understand the phenomenon being investigated, this study is exploratory in nature and lends itself to a qualitative research approach. To that end, face-to-face, semi-structured interviews were conducted with Lebanese HRM representatives working in large (100+ employees) private organizations in four different industries. The interviews were in-depth and open ended with the intention of exploring the issues addressed in the literature as practiced and perceived by local organizations and the impact of several national institutional, socioeconomic and political factors in TM in practice.

### *Procedures and instruments*

Data collection commenced by contacting HR departments within large organizations to inform them about the objectives of the study and to invite for participation. A majority of organizations were unwilling to participate, so a purposeful approach was used, focusing on a convenience sample and a mixed sampling strategy incorporating snowball and chain referral sampling (Patton, 2002). Eventually, semi-structured, in-depth interviews were conducted with 21 HRM representatives. The interview protocol and research questions were based on our overview of the literature of TM research, its shortcomings, scholarly calls and suggestions for future TM-related research studies made by previous studies, along with the relevant TM/HRM studies conducted in Lebanon and the Arab world. The interviews with the HRM representatives focused on understanding the talent philosophy of the organizations, their approach to TM or a description of their TM programs and the TM program in practice – as in how talent is identified, trained, assessed and retained, the factors that influence the processes and challenges faced (if any). All of the interviews were conducted in English. The interviews with the HRM representatives were conducted in their offices as per their choice. All the interviews were recorded and transcribed.

### *The study's sample and profile of the interviewees*

In this study, interviews were conducted with HRM representatives of organizations in four different industries, including six banks, five hotels, five hospitals and five retail organizations. The mean age of the interviewees was 40 years, all had at least a tertiary education, at least five years of experience in the HR/TM field and had been working for their employer for at least four years.

### *The data analysis*

The data collected were analyzed thematically using a template analysis (Tlaiss, 2014). As per the suggestions of King (1994), the thematic analysis of texts required the creation of an initial code book based on the themes identified in the review of literature and guided by the research questions and the interview protocol (Miles and Huberman, 1994; Strauss and Corbin, 1990). The initial code book included the different approaches to explain the nature of talent as well as the different perspectives on TM. The analysis was thus deductive in nature and the analysis and presentation of findings were in line with the themes highlighted in the review of the literature. The analysis was initially conducted on the transcription of every interview and then the findings were systematically compared across interviews to identify themes. Thus, a systematic comparison (a) between the answers of the interviewees and the preliminary code book of themes to identify convergent themes (Miles and Huberman, 1994) and (b) among the interviewees themselves to identify similarities and differences was undertaken. If and when divergence arose, issues were discussed with the other independent, knowledgeable researchers until all agreed on emerging themes. Axial coding was thus conducted to modify the initial code book and include the emerging themes (Tlaiss, 2014). Ultimately, the original and new themes were incorporated in a final coding template (Strauss and Corbin, 1990). After conducting 17 interviews with HRM experts, recurring themes were identified and it was clear that additional data collection was less likely to uncover new information. Nevertheless, to increase the reliability of the findings, four new interviews were conducted and no new themes emerged, suggesting that theoretical saturation had been reached (Strauss and Corbin, 1990).

To ensure the reliability of the data, several approaches were used (Guba and Lincoln, 1994). First, the empirical data collection process was reviewed by researchers with expertise in qualitative research from the university where the researcher was employed and also from other universities. Second, expert peers were asked to review the coding structure and audit the interview protocol and a random sample of transcriptions. Third, peer researchers were also invited to ask critical questions, cross check the analysis process and review the emerging patterns. These steps were taken to ensure the credibility of the conclusions made. Follow-up discussions with the interviewees were also conducted to confirm themes and interpretations.

## Findings

The findings of the interviews with the HRM representatives are presented below. To maintain the confidentiality of our interviewees, pseudonyms are used. Table 1 summarizes the main findings.

### *Talent philosophy*

The exclusivity of talent was widespread across the organizations in Lebanon, regardless of the industry in which they operated. Talent was variously described as "something that makes an individual different than others/ allows others to stand out" (Rola: retail 1), "people with special/unusual/different/rare/unique abilities" (Ameen: hospital 3; Fareed: retail 4),

| Economic sector | Talent philosophy | Talent management | Talent identification | Training and development | Performance assessment | Talent retention |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Banking | Exclusive/ developable | Stream 4: differentiated HR architecture | University graduates with high GPAs and high potential | Job rotation along with customized workshops | Multisource assessments | Formal: penalty clauseInformal: salary increases and continuous development opportunities |
| Hotel | Exclusive/ stable | Stream 3: generic management of talent | Star employees based on performance assessments | The same as provided to other employees | The same as all other employees | None |
| Hospital | Exclusive/ stable | Stream 3: generic management of talent | Star employees based on performance assessments | The same as provided to other employees | The same as all other employees | None |
| Retail | Exclusive/ developable | Stream 4: differentiated HR architecture | Star employees with the highest level of potential/ motivation | Job rotation along with customized workshops | Multisource assessments | Formal: penalty clauseInformal: salary increases and continuous development opportunities |

**Table 1.**
The approach of organizations to talent philosophies and talent management in practice

"people with a gift" (Jana: bank 2) and "those with valuable abilities that help them succeed" (Rabih: hotel 1). Hence, talent was perceived as rare and a criterion differentiating the minority from the majority.

However, there appears to be interindustry differences regarding the stability versus the ability to develop these valuable/rare/special abilities. While hospitals and hotels promoted the exclusive/stable talent philosophy, banks and retail organizations advocated the exclusive/developable talent philosophy and stressed the need to further train and develop talented employees to help them shine or excel. These differing talent philosophies, discussed further in subsequent sections, have an undisputable impact on the overall understanding of TM and on the approach toward talent identification.

> Talented people are those few others with special and rare abilities that have the potential to excel if they work on themselves to develop the special abilities, they have. . .Talented people who do not work on developing or improving their talents or who do not practice them, end up losing them (Fadi: bank 1).

> To be talented, it means you have something rare that others do not have, such as an engaging personality. . .those who have the talent should capitalize on these issues to succeed (Maha: hotel 3).

*Approach to talent management*

The approach of Lebanese organizations to TM differed across industries. While the banking and retail industries were aligned with the differentiated HR architecture promoted by the fourth stream of TM studies, the hospital and hotel industries were closely aligned with generic management, focusing only on hiring talented employees.

*Banks and retail organizations.* The process of TM in banks and retail organizations starts with the identification of strategic roles and supervisory/managerial positions – identified as branch/assistant branch manager in banks and store/assistant store manager/staff supervisor in the retail industry. The HRM department is then expected to create a pool of talented employees with outstanding abilities and huge potential and prepare them to handle these positions in due course. TM thus is executed over several phases. Phase 1 entails the identification of talented people leading to the creation of a talent pool. In phase 2, the pool of talented employees undergoes intensive training of various forms (discussed below) for two to five years to equip and prepare them to fill important positions. Phase 3 includes assessing the overall performance of this talented group of people and assigning them critical positions where they will be expected to create value and increase the competitiveness of the organization. These organizations believe that their talent pool will create value and will enhance competitive advantage. The underlying idea therefore is one of value creation, as illustrated by the following excerpts:

> Our objective is to enhance our competitive advantage in the market, so the job of the talent management team is to bring in those smart people who will create value by doing things differently and increase our competitive advantage, we train them and prepare them to be the future branch managers. . . (Zeina: bank 3).

> Our main focus is our stores. . .that is where all the money comes from, so the store manager and the assistant store manager are the positions we make sure that only our talented people occupy. . . (Akram: retail 2).

According to HRM representatives in banks and retail corporations, this approach to TM was originally devised in response to the loss of talent resulting from the migration of talent from Lebanon to other parts of the world, especially to the GCC nations. To develop a pool of loyal employees, the talent pool is promised a fast career path to supervisory/managerial positions.

*Hotels and hospitals.* For hospitals, their approach to TM was generic in nature with no regard for specific positions and a belief that only talented employees should be hired. Indeed, they focused on hiring students with good academic performance and later on the identification of good performers using periodic performance assessments. The employees with the highest assessments were retained and those not meeting the standards were asked to leave. This approach to TM was possible given the large number of graduates from Lebanese universities housing colleges of medicine, nursing and other medical field-related specialties.

> . . .We only hire the best out there. . .the talented only for all the positions in the hospital whether it is for the job of a nurse or administrative assistant or surgeon. . . (Fadwa: hospital 5).

As for the hotels, their approach was similar to that of the hospitals in terms of hiring only talented employees. They were also similar in terms of their focus on the results of performance assessments. In other words, as employees gain more experience and as vacancies arise in supervisory/managerial roles, these positions are given to the most competent among the talented employees.

> Our talent management work is about identifying the talented people. . .based on their performance assessments. . .then as they gain more experience, we promote them. . . (Ziad: hotel 4).

### *Talent management in practice*

The following section is divided into several subsections and considers in detail how talent is identified, trained, assessed and retained in Lebanese organizations.

### *The identification of talent*

The identification of talent clearly differed based on the industry in which the organizations operated.

*Banks.* For Lebanese banks, talent identification was aligned with their talent philosophy and TM approach. The foundation of their TM program was based on the creation of a talent pool of young, exceptional university graduates. The banks participated in career fairs at the best universities (American and French) in Lebanon and collected resumes and transcripts from young graduates interested in a career in the banking industry. Talent was thus identified among the university graduates majoring in fields related to the banking industry's operations, such as business and economics, with a particular focus on students with a high grade point average (GPA). The graduates with the highest GPAs were contacted and invited to take up a series of written tests administered by the banks. The tests assessed each graduate's potential based on various indicators, including knowledge of business concepts as well as critical thinking, cognitive ability, knowledge of concepts (including technology) and writing skills. The young graduates with the highest scores on these tests were shortlisted and invited to an interview with the HR department, where the focus was mainly on identifying those with ambition, the desire to lead others and a willingness to grow and develop. Ability to handle complex situations, sociability, ability to interact with customers and employees, communication skills, emotional stability, loyalty and adaptability were also desired qualities. At the end of this process, those who achieved the highest scores were identified as talent or high potential and were offered employment.

The banks primarily focused on potential and the growth dimension of talent. However, potential or the individual's ability to grow cannot be measured directly so the focus was on adaptability, learning orientation and motivation that facilitate development and growth. This approach to TM had been successful due to three main reasons: (1) the large numbers of university graduates in Lebanon; (2) the interest of a large number of graduates in working in the banking industry because of the salaries offered and the job security provided in comparison to other industries; (3) the challenge that the TM program offers as well as the faster career path to supervisory and managerial positions.

The HRM representatives clearly stressed the pressure that *wasta* exerted on their ability to administer TM programs. The interviewees spoke about the pressures from influential people occupying various prestigious positions in government as well as from important clients who pressurized them to accept candidates with low GPAs or low scores on admission tests. Despite the frustrations expressed by the HRM representatives about the use of *wasta*, they nevertheless confirmed their compliance with it to help the bank maintain good connections with the government and key clients.

> Given that we are in Lebanon, wasta cannot be avoided…so what if *X* did not graduate from the American University of Beirut, if we get a phone call from Colonel *X* or Minister *Y*, we still have to let him or her sit for the exam…. (Ghada: bank 5).

> One the main problems that I face is wasta. Some of the candidates fail in our admission tests despite their good GPAs, but they resort to their wastas and then I get a call from senior management asking to allow someone who failed to get into the program because of his wasta… (Raed: bank 6).

*Retail organizations.* In the retail industry, talent identification is a two-step procedure. The on-the-job performance of new employees forms the basis of a talent pool of candidates. Hence, the newly hired employees who receive high performance evaluation scores will be interviewed by the director of the TM team or HRM specialists to explore their levels of motivation as well as their interest in growth. Those who pass the interviews will then comprise the talent pool for the organization. Although the first step of this approach is aligned with the stable talent philosophy, the emphasis on growth and motivation in the second step is aligned with the exclusive/developable talent philosophy.

> When employees start working, they are all motivated, but with time this motivation goes down…also we do not know who will actually do a good job…so the high performers…those who get good assessments by their supervisors are the ones we focus on and from this group we choose those who we believe offer the best potential and the strongest desire to grow and be a store manager (Suha: retail 5).

*Hotels and hospitals.* In hotels and hospitals, the HRM representatives emphasized the rigor of hiring criteria and argued that all employees are considered to be talented. The hospitals in our sample were affiliated with colleges of medicine in the best universities in Lebanon, while the hotels were affiliated with culinary schools and hospitality-education centers and hence attracting the next generation of talent was not difficult for either industry. In other words, in identifying talent, the hotels and hospitals in Lebanon focused on measuring the foundational aspects of talented employees through considering excellent performance assessment results as indicators of intelligence and cognitive abilities. The employees who were to be considered part of the talent pool in hotels and hospitals were identified based on their on-the-job performance and thus, the identification of talent was aligned with the talent philosophy. In other words, those who have the highest performance assessments end up being part of the talent pool.

> If one or two employees continue to outperform their colleagues and continue to get excellent performance assessments, these employees get identified as our talent pool…and with time, they will get promoted (Makram: hospital 1).

### *Training and development of talent*

*Banks and retail organizations.* Given that the TM programs in the banking and retail industries are based on the identification of strategic roles, the talent pool undergoes training and development geared toward preparing participants for these positions. During the training and development phase (i.e. the initial two to five years of employment with the bank/retail company), talented hires undergo intensive on-the-job and off-the-job training. The on-the-job component involves two rounds of job rotations: the first is across the various positions and tasks performed at the branch (including cashier, opening new bank accounts, customer services activities, such as filling applications for new credit cards, compliance work, completing credit facilities requests,. . .) or the store (including ironing and folding clothes, receiving and handling inventory, internal design of the store, cashier, payroll,. . .). The objective of this first rotation is to help the talented employees understand all the various activities that take place at the branch and store levels and hence be well prepared to manage all of these activities in the future.

After the completion of the first round, a second round of job rotation starts at the departmental level whereby the talented employees spend a few months in different departments, including HRM, credit, finance and legal to establish a more comprehensive understanding of the business of their employer. At the end of these two rounds of job rotation, the talent pool is assigned to different branches/stores as replacements for employees on leave or to fill in a certain role until a full-time employee is hired. According to the HRM representatives, these assignments to different departments/locations allow the talented employees to work with managers with different management styles and hence improve their communication and leadership style. The off-the-job training typically includes in-house workshops and seminars that focus on improving communication skills with colleagues, managers and clients, leadership skills and general knowledge regarding the industry's operations. For example, the banking talent pool participants attend monthly workshops discussing changes in local and international laws governing banks and banking operations, advances in risk management techniques or new software used in the credit department.

> Our talent goes through training for at least two years so when they get to be branch managers, they are familiar with all the activities that are performed in the branch. . .they also do a rotation in the headquarters' departments so they know everything related to the banking sector (Nadeem: bank 4).

*Hotels and hospitals.* Given Lebanon's dire economic and financial situation, training budgets at hospitals and hotels have been significantly reduced to a very minimal level. As per the HRM representatives in these organizations, the talented employees do not undergo special off-the-job training or development programs. Nevertheless, the on-the-job training exists through coaches and mentors assigned to talented employees with 10 years tenure. These coaches were expected to help the talented employees learn about the organization and its culture, while the mentors were expected to provide them with support in decision-making. However, these coaches and mentors were not part of any formal training and development program and were assigned as the HR manager/director might see fit or by the HR managers themselves as demonstrated in the quotes below.

> I schedule semi-annual meetings with the talent pool. I listen to them to try to understand their experiences and provide them with some mentoring and encouragement on how to advance their careers (Rabih: hotel 1).

> The private hospitals in Lebanon are facing financial stress. . .we cannot afford paying the talented employees better salaries or giving them training. . .so what we do is try to align them with more senior people who can help them learn about the culture of the organization or the industry (Rima: hospital 2).

### *Performance assessment and retention of talent*

*Banks and retail organizations.* The talented employees in the banking and retail industries undergo multisource assessments or 360-degree feedback throughout the training period, whereby feedback is solicited from various direct supervisors and managers, colleagues they have worked with, as well as clients. Based on these evaluations, the talented employees receive individualized advice and feedback on how to improve their performance as well as coaching and mentoring from the TM team or dedicated TM advisor. Here as well, the star performers are promoted to supervisory or managerial roles faster than the rest of the employee base. In terms of retention, the biggest threats to retain the talent pool are more financially rewarding offers from companies operating in the GCC countries (though these have declined over time, given nationalization initiatives (Sidani and Al Ariss, 2014) in these countries), international companies operating locally or local smaller entities that provide a slightly better salary with less training and development opportunities and a less predictable career path. The formal retention strategy used is a penalty clause in employment contracts whereby employees hired as part of the TP cannot leave their employer until they have matched the years of training with actual employment. So, if they were in training for two years, they had to work for at least another two years before being able to leave. Those who choose to leave early have to repay all bonuses received while in the TM program. Informal strategies include salary increases and bonuses based on performance along with coaching exercises that remind the talent of their continuous learning and development, career progression and advancement and growth in their financial package.

> The TM program contract is clear. . .. we invest in their training and they have to work for us for the same period whereby they were learning (Feras: retail 3).

> When they join our banks in the talent program, they are making a legally binding agreement to stay with us for a minimum period of time. . ..If they wish to leave earlier, they have to pay a penalty. . .They have to return to us all the bonuses that they received throughout their years of work with us as part of the talent program (Jana: bank 2).

*Hotels and hospitals.* Given the absence of a clear TM approach in the hotels and hospitals, it was unsurprising to learn that talented employees are assessed in the same manner as other employees. Despite claims regarding the value-added contribution made by talented employees, the HRM representatives did not have any formal retention strategies in place. The finances of the hotels and hospitals do not allow them to increase salaries to match the offers made by counterparts in the GCC. The HRM representatives spoke about the difficult economic conditions in Lebanon and their inability to offer higher salaries. They spoke about the increasing cost of living in Lebanon and the interest of the majority of their talented employees in leaving the country in search of better living conditions. Accordingly, they did not invest in special training for their talent pool but spoke about minimal salary increases and adjustments in work schedules that were offered on an *ad-hoc* basis as attempts to retain talent that has received an employment offer elsewhere. Furthermore, high unemployment increased the supply of labor and hence facilitated the process of hiring people when needed, thus reducing the rationale for having retention strategies.

> If they have a better offer in Dubai or Qatar, I cannot do anything about it. . .if I get a better offer, I will leave as well. . . (Yasmeen: hotel 2).

> We are already paying them good salaries in comparison to what other economic sectors are paying. . .so if they do not like it, they can leave. . .the unemployment level here is very high and it is not difficult to find new people (Makram: hospital 1).

## Discussion

The present study is an exploratory investigation of key TM issues in the context of Lebanon. Regarding *talent philosophies*, the dominant approach was that of exclusivity supported by the resource-based view (Barney, 1991), where talented people are perceived as rare resources that create value for the organization and strengthen its competitive advantage. In line with Meyers and VanWorkom's (2014) framework of talent philosophies, our findings reveal that Lebanese companies believe that talent is either exclusive/developable or exclusive/stable, thus adhering to the elitist approach to talent which is strongly promoted in the TM literature (Boudreau and Ramstad, 2005; Collings and Mellahi, 2009). In line with Meyers *et al.* (2019), the argument can clearly be made that Lebanese organizations, independent of industry, use exclusive talent philosophies and this could be attributable to their large size.

In terms of the *process of TM*, our findings indicate the widespread salience of the third and the fourth streams. In line with findings reported in previous studies (Becker and Huselid, 2006; Boudreau and Ramstad, 2007; Cappelli, 2008; Lepak and Snell, 1999, 2002), the banks and the retail organizations adhered to the fourth stream, championed by Collings and Mellahi (2009), wherein pivotal roles are identified as the starting point. TM in Lebanese banks and retail organizations included recruiting the best people and finding positions for them later, while keeping in mind that these talented people are hired to be assigned to strategic, pivotal, important and supervisory/managerial roles only. The focus was on external recruitment to create the talent pool and internal development to make sure that there is sufficient talent to meet organizational needs for talent to fill strategic roles. This suggests the salience of the bottom-up (Lepak and Snell, 1999) approach to TM, emphasizing the idea that employees who are valuable and unique can contribute to the firm's strategic objectives by virtue of their talent. The similarity could be attributed to the fact that despite the tough economic backdrop, the banking and retail industries have remained strong. Unlike the banks and retail organizations, the hospitals and hotels adhered to a generic approach to TM based primarily on the creation of a pool of talented employees based on performance assessments. Their main focus was on identifying top performers and then promoting them as vacancies become available. This finding also demonstrates the relevance of IT (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983) and the economic situation. The tourism industry has been negatively influenced by the political instability in Lebanon, while several hospitals have considered closing their doors in the absence of financial support from the government. The argument can be made that the unfavorable contextual economic and political situation drives the lack of investment made by some industries in developing their TM programs. To that end, we highlight the overall importance of IT and the impact that local institutional factors have in terms of supporting the adoption of similar approaches to TM by companies in the same industry.

Regarding *talent identification*, our findings illustrate differences across industries based on differing talent philosophies. The talent philosophy of the banks and retail organizations paved the way for their capitalization on the growth dimension (Silzer and Church, 2009) in their approach to talent identification. Employees' potential was the main focus of the banks and retail organizations in Lebanon. Potential was initially spotted based on cognitive abilities and if complemented with a desire to lead and ambition, then was identified as talent and included as part of the talent pool. Hence, talent identification and recruitment in these two industries were not driven by vacancies but were conducted in a proactive manner in anticipation of potential future needs or vacancies and following the approach recommended by TM scholars, including Collings and Mellahi (2009). The talent pool in the banks and retail organizations receive preferential treatment in terms of starting salaries, training and development and shortened career paths to supervisory/management roles in comparison to regular employees progressing through the ranks. Although singling out talent and giving talented people preferential or differentiated treatment was not seen as a challenge in other country-specific investigations (see for example Skuza *et al.*, 2013; Valverde *et al.*, 2013), the reliance of some candidates on personal connections or *wasta* was a challenge faced by the banks as well as the other organizations in our study. This finding thus highlights the role of institutional factors and how the salience of a patriarchal, collective mentality can challenge the practical implementation of TM. Social influence has ensured that Lebanese companies adopted practices that were consistent with their institutional environment and ensured their survival within it to further strengthen their legitimacy through attending to normative pressures as per IT (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983). Furthermore, the focus of the banks on hiring external talent among young university graduates based on the local workforce characteristics can be perceived as coercive isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983).

In terms of hotels and hospitals, talent identification was based on their talent philosophy, focusing primarily on the foundational dimension related to superior on-the-job performance. Given that the TM approach in Lebanese hospitals and hotels was not based on a differentiated HR architecture and given the understanding of talent as being stable, the talented employees were not due to receive any special treatment in terms of salaries or training, their overall TM practices were conducted in the form of the generic management of talent. In contrast with the majority of TM literature reviews that highlight the difficulties in attracting talent (Scullion and Collings, 2011; Tarique and Schuler, 2010), identifying, attracting and recruiting talent was not seen as a challenge for the organizations in Lebanon. This could be the result of the abundance of young graduates and high unemployment levels. It could also be the result of the unstable and turbulent political and economic environment in Lebanon and thus providing strong evidence of how organizations in Lebanon gain legitimacy by adapting similar TM practices by virtue of isomorphism as per IT (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983). From an institutional perspective, our findings illustrate how local contextual and institutional factors, including economic and political forces along with workforce characteristics impact TM in practice, thus highlighting the importance of IT in guiding TM research, given how the TM practices unfold in this study and the strong influence of local contextual variables.

Regarding *talent training and development*, the hotels and hospitals (with the exception of some coaching and mentoring executed in an informal manner and on *ad-hoc* basis) are not conducting any because they cannot afford to do so. The HRM representatives in these organizations stressed the negative impact of the difficult economic situation in Lebanon and hence, the pressures they face in reducing, if not eliminating, all sorts of training and development activities in an attempt to help their companies cut costs. The emphasis on training in the banks is best perceived as another example of coercive isomorphism, whereby since 1991, Lebanese banks have been required by the Department of Training and Development within the framework of the Secretariat General of the Association of Banks in Lebanon (2013) to develop a training policy that is consistent with their needs and profile. Nevertheless, the talent pools within banks and retail organizations receive training tailored to improve their potential in order to achieve what Meyers and van Woerkam (2014) referred to as the optimum fit between individuals' potential and stimulating environmental conditions to generate a series of synergistic or multiplicative person–environment interactions aiming to help their talent generate superior performance. As suggested by previous studies (Becker and Huselid, 2006; Lepak and Snell, 1999), the importance of the positions destined to be filled by the talent pool justified the disproportionate investment in specialized training and development programs. Unlike what was reported by Skuza *et al.* (2013), developing soft skills (punctuality, communication, presentation, etc.) was considered as important as improving technical skills since the overall objective was to create a pool of generalists capable of filling supervisory/management positions. The intensity of the training program and its consequences were the primary challenges faced by these organizations at this stage and were attended to by using monetary rewards based on performance and formal and informal sessions that helped boost motivation. Here as well, the influence of local institutional factors is highly visible as the companies in the same industry end up adhering to the same TM-related practices.

Given the heavy investments made in developing talent by the retail organizations and the banks, these organizations capitalize on a 360-degree assessment to identify their star performers among their talent pool and then focus on grooming them for promotion to assistant/manager positions. Similarly, the organizations in the banking and retail industries have devised some formal and *informal retention* measures to ensure a good return on their investment. In other words, talented hires must commit to staying with their employers for a minimum number of years. Those who decide to leave early face financial penalties. Although this finding contradicts those reported in recent studies (see Skuza *et al.*, 2013; Tlaiss *et al.*, 2017; Valverde *et al.*, 2013) regarding the absence of formal policies for talent management, it confirms the existence of formal and informal retention policies in Lebanon. The manner by which good performance and loyalty to one employer positively impacts career advancement through the managerial hierarchy hints at the existence of organizational career paths in Lebanese organizations, as previously suggested by Tlaiss (2014). This instrumental approach to employees is also promoted by the hospitals and hotels in Lebanon who justify the lack of retention measures for talent, given the wide availability of labor as a result of high unemployment. Accordingly, this paper argues that the overall perceptions of the nature of talent, the approach to TM in practice, as well as the retention policies deployed can be interpreted within the lines of mimetic isomorphism as per IT (DiMaggio and Powell, 1983).

## Implications and contributions

The findings of this study have important implications for TM research and practice.

Drawing on the different approaches to TM identified in this study, more research among HR practitioners is certainly needed to better understand both how talent is conceptualized and also the TM approaches of choice in the Arab world and across different industries. The findings of this study highlight the fact that institutional factors are not to be taken lightly as they play a significant role in crafting the approach, perception and practice of TM in Lebanon. Thus, we argue against the assumptions that TM concepts can be generalized across cultures. We also emphasize the need for further studies that can help us understand whether aspects of TM are indeed universal and transferable across cultures, without accounting for institutional specifics and more importantly whether aspects of TM have to be universal versus specific to industries and countries based on different institutional variables. Notwithstanding the fact that this study is of exploratory nature and the fact that it focuses on one country in the Arab world, we cannot but wonder about the relevance of the "war for talent" outside the context of developed countries and MNCs. To further explain, previous studies have gone to great lengths to discuss the "war for talent" among MNCs and its implications. However, looking at our findings from a bird's eye view, the abundance of highly educated youth in Lebanon prevents local organizations from experiencing any war for talent, despite their exclusive approach to the nature of talent. The surplus of talent in Lebanon gives the local organizations the freedom to choose who to hire, impose their own regulations and even take a generic approach to TM (e.g. hotels and hospitals). Indeed, organizations in the financially stable banking and retail sector adopted advanced TM practices, but the question is to what extent did these advanced TM practices contribute to their competitive advantage in comparison to other organizations that adhered to a generic approach to TM?

To that end, we argue that as far as decision makers and managers are involved, TM should be approached as a project that needs to be tailored to fit the institutional needs and conditions of companies operating in specific economic sectors, given the pattern for organizations operating in certain industries to mimic competitors. So for example, given the financially stronger position of the banks and retail organizations in Lebanon, their approach to TM was more contemporary in nature and based on the Western-best practices.

However, the hospitals and hotels in Lebanon could not adhere to a similar approach, given their unstable financial status. Consequently, the different approaches to TM described in this study have merits and drawbacks but are bound by the institutional boundaries of each economic sector/industry and the institutional factors of the country. HR managers also have an important role to play in terms of fostering organizational cultures that promote awareness about what TM actually entails. This seems to be a very important issue in the context of Lebanon, given that the hotels and hospitals have talent management departments but their activities, in reality, were primarily *ad-hoc* in nature and aligned or similar to the administrative tasks of the HRM department in terms of hiring, promotion and performance assessment.

In this paper, the following contributions to the broader TM theory and literature are made. First, a contribution to TM research is made by shedding light on how TM unfolds in practice. We provide further support to improve our understanding of how the nature of talent is actually understood in practice as well as how TM unfolds as a process within organizations in various industries. The differentiation approach to TM (Boudreau and Ramstad, 2005; Collings and Mellahi, 2009) and the identification of talent as a strategic resource are thus supported. This conceptualization is consistent with the resource-based view of HRM (Barney, 1991), which considers people to be key resources based on their human capital, while emphasizing their ability to improve if given the opportunity to work in challenging environments (Lepak and Snell, 1999, 2002; Nijs *et al.*, 2014). Nevertheless, it is possible to argue that the TM field needs more empirical research to better understand the ways in which talent is understood and TM is executed in organizations operating in the same country. Second, we contribute to TM by widening our understanding of TM beyond the Western contexts and advance TM research by attending to scholarly calls for more studies that seek to understand how TM is impacted by contextual factors. To that effect, we argue that TM research in Lebanon and the Arab region by extension should be tailored to the local economic and demographic challenges. To further explain, the peculiarity of labor market conditions in Lebanon in terms of the availability of a well-educated young population paved the way for the organizations in this study to take an exclusive approach to their identification of talent. Furthermore, the economically advantageous position of the banks and retail organizations allowed them to take an advanced, systematic approach to TM with investments made in developing their own talent teams and a well-defined process regarding talent identification, training, assessment and retention. Unlike their counterparts, the hotels and hospitals, while taking advantage of the availability of talent, were constrained by the financial limitations of their organizations and country. These financial constraints resulted in adopting a basic approach to TM. Hence, entrepreneurs interested in ventures in the hospitals and hotels sectors are capable of differentiating themselves if they adopt a more systematic approach to TM. Third, support for IT is demonstrated by the construct of isomorphism in explaining how local contextual and institutional factors influence the manner by which TM is implemented in Lebanon. In doing so, it is demonstrated that political, economic and social transformations in Lebanon make understanding of local national contexts and institutional influences more challenging and yet all the more important for advancing TM research, both theoretically and empirically. For example, the high unemployment rates and the low salaries granted the organizations an advantage in their approach to talent, given the high demand for jobs. Therefore, considering the country-specific context and understanding the major economic and workforce demographic conditions of Lebanon were useful for understanding TM.

## Limitations and suggestions for future research

Our study highlights some of the emerging trends in TM in four industries in Lebanon, with the objective of providing a platform for future studies into this underresearched topic, country and region of the world. Therefore, the findings cannot claim to reflect a comprehensive understanding of TM in Lebanon and there is cognizance of the limitations of this study. First, the generalizability of the findings across different industries is difficult to discern. Future studies are encouraged to focus on exploring TM in specific industries to better understand TM practices. Second, this study focused on understanding the nature of talent and TM practices in general in local companies. Studies that compare TM practices in more depth between the local companies and MNCs operating in Lebanon are important to better understand the convergence and divergence trends in TM practices. Third, a qualitative approach using a convenience sample was used in this study based on willingness to participate. Although nonprobability sampling and a qualitative approach were deemed appropriate given the exploratory nature of the study and the limited nature of empirical TM-related research in Lebanon, future studies are encouraged to use quantitative techniques and to involve larger samples. Fourth, as the interviews with the HRM representatives were conducted in their offices, one possible limitation could be social desirability bias toward being "politically correct" rather than saying the "truth" for fear of being overheard by colleagues and potentially retaliated against by their employers. Another possible limitation is that this study focused on HRM representatives. Hence, it would be very interesting to see future studies focus on the experience of the talented employees with TM. Fifth, this study is based on data collected before the rise of the political and social unrest in October 2019 and do not reflect its impact on TM in the four economic sectors. Hence, it would be interesting to explore the TM-related consequences of this political and economic crisis, especially on the banks and the retail organizations. Ultimately, it would also be interesting to see future studies identify and explain differences in TM approaches between the countries of the AME, given the heterogeneity of the economic, political and workforce environments of these countries.

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